The morning miracle

Hi everyone, welcome! This is the eleventh episode of the Cottongue Podcast!

[00:00:15] At last, summer has arrived. It's July, and that means the beginning of the holidays. Perhaps you're planning to visit a foreign country, and perhaps even a French-speaking country, meaning a country where French is spoken. If so, I hope you'll take the opportunity to try using the language and see all the progress you've made in French. Above all, I hope my podcast has helped you understand more things, to have a better understanding of French. You'll see that if you go to a French-speaking country, people speak a little faster than I do. You know that for this podcast, I try to speak slowly. Not much more slowly than ordinary people, but slowly enough for you to understand everything I tell you. In any case, I'm very curious to know your holiday plans, what you're planning. So don't hesitate to send me an email to tell me. For my part, I'm planning to return to France for a week. You may know I live in Poland, in Warsaw, so for me the holidays are an opportunity to go back and see my friends and family in France.

[00:02:15] Today, I'm not going to talk about holidays. The subject I've decided to discuss concerns personal development instead: things we can do in everyday life to try to improve ourselves. In the world we live in, there's a lot of stress and fatigue, and sometimes we also have bad habits. We receive a lot of information throughout the day that we have to try to process. Information coming from every direction, received on our screens, on our mobile phones, twenty-four hours a day, seven days a week. With all this, sometimes we feel we're losing control of our lives, that we can no longer control our everyday lives. In any case, more and more people have this feeling, this impression.

[00:03:42] So the question is: how can we avoid this depressing feeling? What can we do when we feel we're always short of time? When we feel we don't have enough time to do everything we'd like or ought to do. We look everywhere for solutions to regain control. For example, we try meditation, we try disconnecting, meaning switching off all our electronic devices, or we can go on spiritual journeys. In short, there are lots of techniques we can try to regain control of our lives. But perhaps the solution is much simpler than we think. Perhaps it's so simple and obvious that we don't see it. Or perhaps we don't want to see it, refuse to see it.

[00:04:57] This solution, the one I'm thinking of, is free, simple, and we can apply it immediately. Or rather, we can apply it the very next morning. Have you guessed what it is? Do you have any idea?

[00:05:21] The solution to this lack of time is simply getting up an hour earlier in the morning. Perhaps some Cottongue Podcast listeners are already early risers. An early riser is someone who gets up early, for example at six in the morning. In French, we call these people "lève-tôt". These people don't need convincing. They already know all the benefits of getting up early. But for most of us, including me, it can be quite difficult. Today, I'll talk about the advantages of getting up early, what's sometimes called the "morning miracle", and give you some advice I found on the internet for developing this good habit, for being able to get up early. But at the end of this podcast, I'll also tell you why it isn't necessarily a

good idea for everyone, why getting up early isn't the solution for every person. So are you ready to talk about the morning miracle? OK, here we go!

[00:07:20] To begin, I'll give you a few definitions, not many, don't worry, only three, to make the rest of this podcast easier to understand. That way, I'm sure you understand the words I'll use. The first important word is "sommeil", sleep. Sleep is simply the state we're in when we're sleeping. That's the first word, the first definition I wanted to give you: sleep. The second is the verb "se réveiller", to wake up. I'll use this verb a lot in this podcast. It simply means "to come out of sleep", "to stop sleeping". For example, sometimes when we have a nightmare, we wake up, stop sleeping because of it. The third definition is the verb "se lever", to get up. In this context, it means "to get out of bed". So first we wake up, then we get up, meaning we get out of bed and go, for example, to the kitchen for breakfast. That's the verb "se lever". We can also use it when we're sitting on a chair and decide to get up, meaning to stand up.

[00:09:15] In French, we have a proverb: "The world belongs to those who get up early." It means morning people, those who get up early, are generally more successful. The world belongs to them, meaning it's theirs. There are many examples of these people, for example directors and entrepreneurs. They're very successful people with a habit of getting up early. You probably know Tim Cook, the CEO of Apple. Well, Tim Cook habitually gets up at 4:30 in the morning. That's extremely early!

[00:10:16] But why, actually, should we get up early? What are the advantages? First, because it's the only time of day we truly manage, over which we have total control. And this time doesn't affect the schedule for the rest of the day. That means if you get up an hour earlier, it won't have consequences for the rest of your day. By contrast, if you get up an hour later, you'll be late for work and that will have many consequences for your day, generally rather negative ones.

[00:11:19] What can you do with the time you gain by getting up earlier? How can we use this time if we get up an hour earlier in the morning?

[00:11:35] There are two schools of thought. The first says we should use this time to take time for ourselves, do things that interest us. Things that aren't urgent but are important to us, and that we never have time to do. I'm thinking, for example, of meditation, exercise and reading, if there's a book you've wanted to read for a long time but never find time for. It can also mean creative activities, for example drawing, painting or playing a musical instrument. But you need to think about your neighbours, because if you start playing the trumpet at five in the morning, perhaps they won't be very happy.

[00:12:36] In fact, by getting up earlier, we finally have time for all these things we usually never have the opportunity to do. It's even better for things requiring daily practice, for example learning a language. If you get up an hour earlier, you can use that hour to do a little French, listen to a podcast or watch videos on YouTube. By getting up an hour earlier, you can do a little French every day.

[00:13:20] The second school says we should use this hour for the most important things. It says we should begin the day with an achievement. If we finish something quickly first thing in the morning, we're more effective for the rest of the day. Then we can continue and tackle

our other tasks. This important thing might be sending an email or finishing a presentation, all these things useful at work. In the morning, our brain is fresh and rested, so our ideas are clearer and it's easier to concentrate on important projects.

[00:14:19] If you want to create your start-up, your own business, you can use this extra morning hour to work on the project. Every morning, you work on your start-up project for an hour, then go to work normally, without taking a risk. That way, every day you make a little more progress on your project.

[00:14:53] If you get up early, you have time to plan your day properly, organise yourself well, and ultimately perhaps feel less stressed. You know exactly what you have to do, have organised your schedule well, and will be able to do everything on your to-do list.

[00:15:30] Now the question is: how can we manage to get up earlier every morning?

[00:15:39] A study at a German university showed that around 10% of people are morning people. In other words, 10% function better in the morning. By contrast, 20% are considered "night owls". Night owls are people who stay awake late in the evening and whose brains function better at night. The remaining 70% belong to neither group, neither of these categories. That means most people have a regular sleep rhythm, a regular sleep cycle. But for most of us, getting up early seems an insurmountable challenge, something impossible. Many people who go to bed late think it's impossible for them to get up early. They say it isn't something they're capable of. In reality, most of us can adapt to a new sleep rhythm. It's all a question of method. Everything depends on the method we adopt.

[00:17:26] So I'll give you some advice for adopting a method that will let you change your sleep rhythm to get up earlier.

[00:17:41] The first important thing is to know how many hours of sleep you need. We often hear that eight hours is the magic number for being fully rested, for recharging our batteries. But in reality, there isn't really a magic number. It depends on the person. Some people function very well on six hours of sleep or less, while others need eight, nine, perhaps ten hours. The best way to know is to test how many hours you need to feel rested and avoid feeling tired for the rest of the day.

[00:18:39] Once you know how many hours of sleep you need, you need to know what time to wake up. That's quite simple. If you usually wake up at seven, your goal will be to get up at six, meaning one hour earlier. An hour is enough time to do something, to do one activity or several without rushing, without hurrying. "To hurry" means doing something quickly. For example, if you're late, you'll hurry to work. Here the objective is precisely not to rush, to take your time.

[00:19:40] Let's imagine you need eight hours of sleep and want to get up at six. You'll have to fall asleep at 22:00, meaning ten in the evening. Here you need to distinguish between "se coucher", to go to bed, and "s'endormir", to fall asleep. "To go to bed" means getting into bed, the opposite of "to get up". "To fall asleep" means beginning to sleep, the opposite of "to wake up". Sometimes we go to bed, go to bed early because we have an important appointment the next day, for example, but can't fall asleep. We lie in bed for hours without

sleeping. That's called "having insomnia". So the important thing here is to fall asleep at ten. If you need thirty minutes to fall asleep, you should go to bed at 21:30, half past nine.

[00:21:02] How can we make sure we fall asleep? A good idea is to have a ritual, an activity we do to calm down, to clear our heads. "To clear our heads" means no longer thinking about the day's problems or work, forgetting all our worries and problems. This activity might be reading or walking, something that lets you take your mind off things and forget your problems. Specialists also recommend switching off your computer and mobile phone and not looking at screens for at least thirty minutes before falling asleep. The light emitted by our electronic devices is bad for our sleep because it makes our brain feel it's still daytime.

[00:22:18] Another important tip for keeping this habit is to get up early at weekends too. At weekends, you can get up at most an hour later. The problem with getting up much later at weekends is that on Monday, returning to your normal rhythm will be very difficult. It might take several days and you'll feel tired. So to avoid losing the benefits of getting up early, keep getting up early at weekends too. That way, you'll also have more time.

[00:23:07] All this is easy to say, of course, but how can we build a good habit? The philosopher Aristotle wrote: "We are what we repeatedly do. Excellence, then, is not an act, but a habit." You understand: to become very good at something, to become excellent, we need to develop a habit, practise something regularly, train regularly. So how can we develop this habit?

[00:23:54] First, we need to start gently. We shouldn't make too radical a change. For example, if you usually get up at seven but your goal is six, simply begin by getting up fifteen minutes earlier. In other words, get up at 6:45 for several weeks. You'll gradually get used to getting up a little earlier, and the change won't be too radical. At this stage, finding an activity you can do in those fifteen minutes is very important. Otherwise, you won't feel the benefits and may think the extra fifteen minutes are useless. After some time, if we think those fifteen minutes are useless, we'll return to our normal rhythm. Once you're used to getting up fifteen minutes earlier, move your alarm forward another fifteen minutes. That means now you'll get up at 6:30. You'll have a little more time for your activity. Keep applying this method until you can get up at six.

[00:25:38] Be careful not to go too fast, not to skip stages. If you try to go too fast and make too radical a change, you may fail. "To fail" means "not to succeed".

[00:25:57] Despite all this good advice, we must also be prepared to fail. Some nights, for one reason or another, you'll sleep badly, and waking up at the planned time will be impossible. You'll probably feel a little disappointed, probably feel bad, but you should know that's normal. We aren't robots. We must be prepared for this scenario, know it will happen. It isn't a drama, isn't a catastrophe, if for a day or two you can't get up at the right time. Gradually, try returning to your good habit and continue until it becomes natural.

[00:27:04] But should everyone get up at five in the morning? When we see all these books and articles, we get the impression that if we get up late, we aren't successful people. We think getting up late makes it impossible to succeed at work. We see all these great directors getting up extremely early and feel obliged to copy them. But all this depends on the person.

[00:27:45] A study published in the journal Elsevier in 2009 shows that people who go to bed later are generally more intelligent. More intelligent people tend to experiment with new lifestyles and adopt new values more quickly. In fact, we're rather programmed to go to bed early. For thousands of years, humans have gone to bed early and got up early. The tendency to go to bed later is quite recent, and many intelligent people follow it because they want to experiment with something new. So if you like going to bed late and getting up late, perhaps it simply means you're more intelligent than others. That's rather good news.

[00:28:54] These studies also showed that people who go to bed and get up late have better reasoning abilities. This study was conducted at the University of Madrid with one thousand students. Among these students, those who managed to solve problems fastest were those accustomed to going to bed late.

[00:29:33] In short, with all this, you can see it's difficult to get a clear picture. Some studies show it's better to get up early, while others show it's better to sleep longer and get up later.

[00:29:52] In conclusion, I think everyone must find what works for them. There isn't really a miracle solution. We all have different lifestyles and responsibilities, and doing everything we'd like isn't always possible. But if you feel you don't have enough time, and you're someone accustomed to going to bed late, trying something different can always be interesting. In other words, it may be interesting to try getting up earlier to see whether this lifestyle suits you.

[00:30:47] That's all for today. Thank you very much for listening to this podcast. I hope it inspired you. Perhaps it made you want to experiment with a new lifestyle and get up a little earlier. If you manage it, send me an email about your results. I'm very curious to know how it works for you.

[00:31:19] Next week, we'll talk about money, particularly people who earn a lot of money through games of chance such as the lottery. And we'll see their lives aren't always perfect. Thank you, everyone, and see you soon!